> "IT WOULD NOT BE WRONG TO CALL THEIR DRILLS BLOODLESS BATTLES AND THEIR BATTLES BLOODY DRILLS."
>
> **FLAVIUS JOSEPHUS**, JEWISH HISTORIAN, DESCRIBING ROMAN TRAINING METHODS

The existence of selection criteria should not be taken to imply, though, that legionaries were a hand-picked elite. Whereas the earlier militia legions had been recruited from citizens meeting a certain property qualification, volunteers for the professional army came predominantly from the lower ranks of society – from the sons of farmers and artisans down to plain vagrants. Roman recruiting parties may have preferred to select tall, robust citizens accustomed to physical labour, but much of the time they presumably had to accept whatever vaguely acceptable candidates presented themselves.

## LIFE IN THE LEGIONS

The attractions of life in the legions were such as would appeal to men who otherwise faced lives blighted by insecurity and poor prospects. Employment as a legionary offered modest pay – probably no more than the income of an ordinary labourer – but a high level of job security, regular meals, and some chance of advancement in life. Usually recruited in his early 20s, the legionary was required to make a daunting commitment. He signed up for 20 years active service plus five years as a "veteran" with lighter duties. During that quarter-century he was likely to be stationed at remote locations on the frontiers of the Empire, subject to rigorous discipline and draconian punishments – the penalty for falling asleep on guard duty was to be clubbed to death by your comrades. In principle, he was not permitted to marry during his service, though human nature proved stronger than regulations and many men raised families while in the army. At the end of his 25 years, the legionary could expect to be rewarded with a grant of land. This was frequently alongside other retired veterans in a military colony.

Whatever their motives for joining up, soldiers were soon bound to the army by ties of group loyalty that were deliberately fostered at every level. Arriving at his designated unit with his lead identity tablet



**Centurion's helmet**
In the early centuries of the Empire a legion usually had a total of 59 centurions. The highest-ranking of these was centurion of the First Century of the First Cohort, who was known as the *primus pilus*.

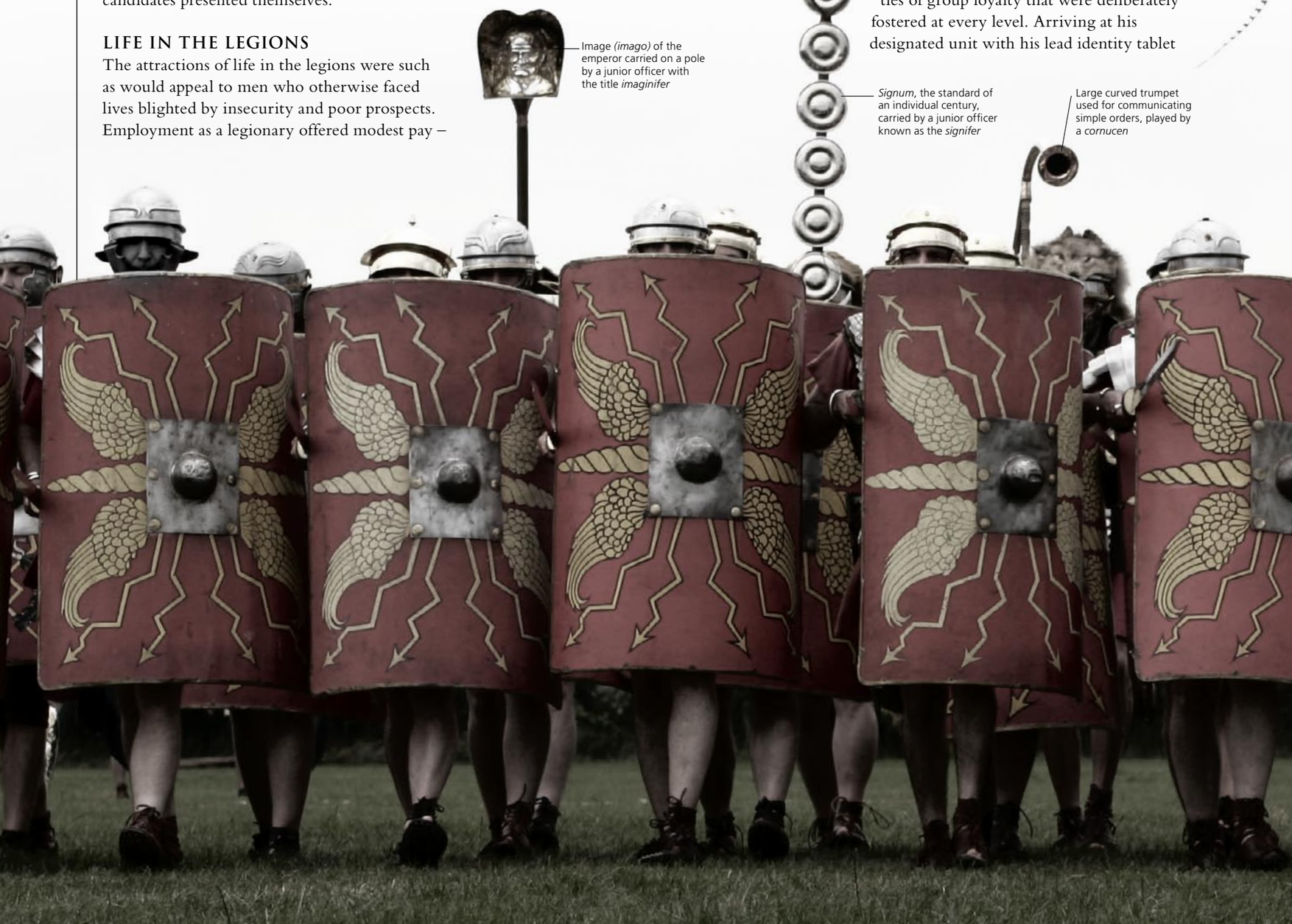


Image *(imago)* of the emperor carried on a pole by a junior officer with the title *imaginifer*

*Signum*, the standard of an individual century, carried by a junior officer known as the *signifer*

Large curved trumpet used for communicating simple orders, played by a *cornucen*